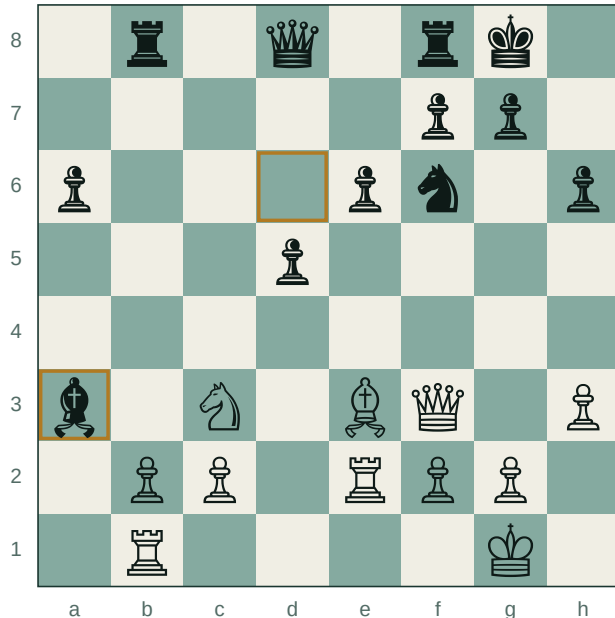


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 20

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 19...Bxa3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20. bxa3 Rxb1+ 21. Nxb1

20.bxa3 The pawn captures the bishop on a3. The changed line means the rook on b1 attacks the rook on b8.
Recorded reply: **20...Rxb1+**.

21.Nxb1 The knight captures the rook on b1.

At the end, nominal material is White 25 / Black 23 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: bishop on a3. Check for tactical protection.